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Explaining funds (Circles) to users who are familiar with Kiva but not well-served by our existing options - August 2025

Report Type	Moment-in-time report
Purpose	Evaluate whether proposed messaging effectively communicates the value of funds to users who are familiar with Kiva but not well-served by our existing options.
Insight	Strong value for existing DAF Pay users; less of a fit with auto-lending and superlenders
Audience	Marketplace User, Giving Fund User
Subsegment	n/a
Current user?	Yes
Behavior	n/a
Impact vertical	n/a
Topics	Hook/ acquisition, Pricing, Incentive
Pages	Kiva Circle
Date	2025-08
Method	Interview
Contributed by	Person hidden

Overview

Objective

Evaluate whether **proposed messaging** effectively communicates the value of funds to users who are familiar with Kiva but not well-served by our existing options.

Identify points of confusion or messaging shifts that may be needed. Look for red flags in the MLP feature set that may prevent value delivery.

Target audience

For this research, we will try to talk to people who have an existing Kiva account but are **not well-served** by Marketplace today.

We are assuming this will include:

Users with large balances + auto-lending

Hypothesis: These users like Kiva and don't require choice. Some might become more active if we can offer a tax receipt.

Users who report giving $10k+ to charity, are in the US, and do not love choosing loans

Hypothesis: These users are not fully satisfied with Kiva today, and might allocate a larger % of their charitable wallet to Kiva if we can offer ease + a tax receipt.

Users who have checked out via DAF Pay

Hypothesis: These users want to support Kiva, and have a charitable wallet that *they were unable to use for lending* in the past.

Results

Based on this research which audiences who have existing Kiva account seem like the **strongest prospects** for funds?

⚠️

Users with large balances + auto-lending

- Value ease, but expect more granular settings than our new product offers (filter on country, loan length)
- 3/4 would use the new product *if it combined existing auto-lending settings with a tax benefit;* 2 mentioned increasing their contributions

❌

Users who report giving $10k+ to charity, are in the US, and do not look forward to choosing loans

- Despite their responses in the annual survey**,** in interviews 3/4 said that *they would be unwilling to give up choice*
- 1 mentioned having a DAF, but did not express interest in using it with Kiva

✅

Users who have checked out via DAF Pay

- 2/2 users who participated in interviews said they would use the product *in addition to manual lending*
- 1 other user with a DAF (had not used DAF Pay on Kiva before) was interested in this
- 3 additional DAF Pay users expressed interest via email

3

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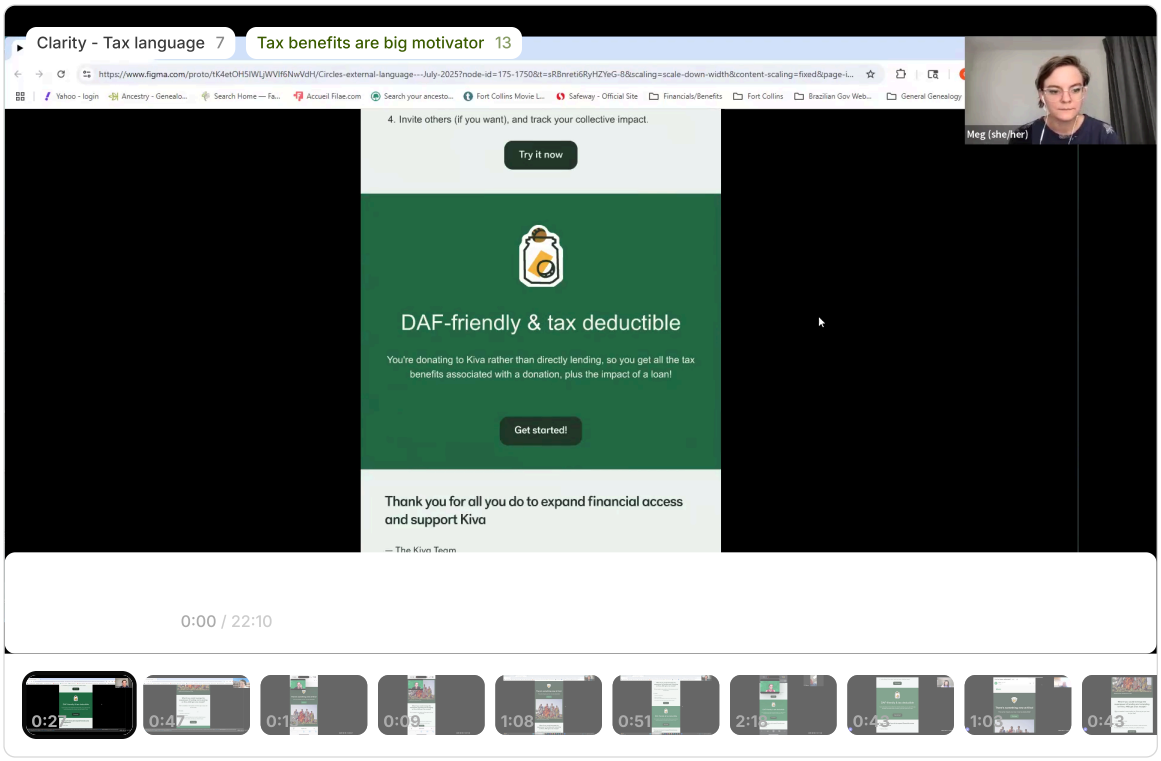
Recommendations

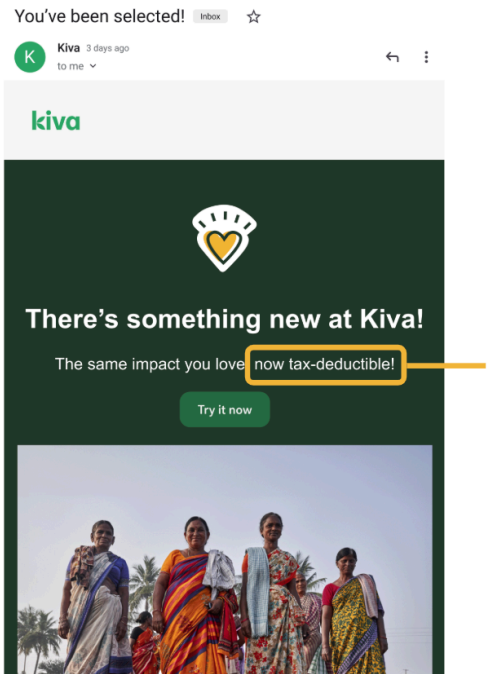
1. **Broaden outreach** beyond current donors or autolenders and focus message on **DAF support**, not taxes
2. Expect existing users to start a fund **in addition to** choosing some manual loans, and start planning for a seamless cross-product experience

3

Detailed results

Reactions to the email





Reactions to this line only

"Ooh, I like this idea...Now tax deductible!" (3)

"In my case, it's more helpful if there's a DAF Pay option." (1)

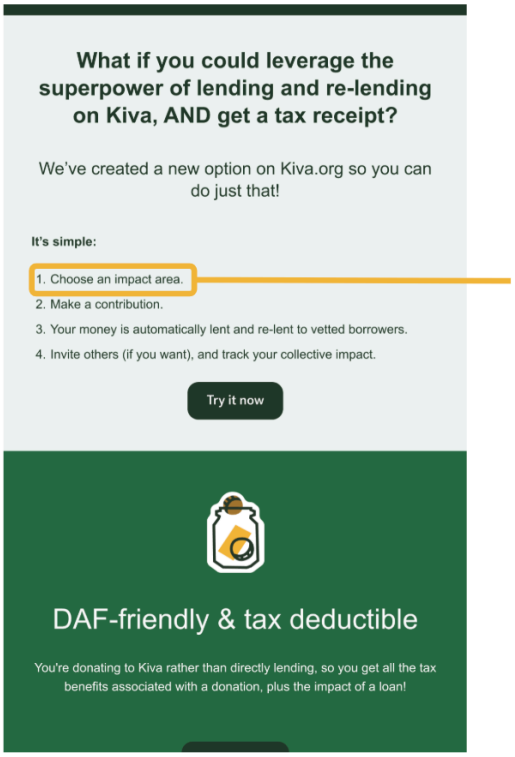
"I thought donations to Kiva were tax deductible... It's not been a 501C3?" (2)

"What are the impact areas [that I'm able to choose for this product]?" (3)

2/3 who asked this had a very specific focus area based on current auto-lending options (and ultimately did not want to use the product)

"In my case, it's more helpful if there's a DAF Pay option." (1)

"I thought donations to Kiva were tax deductible... It's not been a 501C3?" (2)



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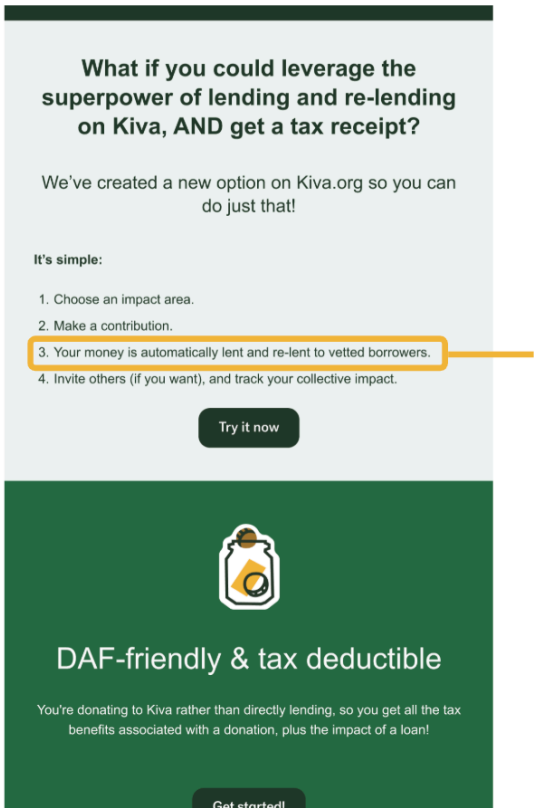


"Do I get to choose?...It's kind of fun to come in and choose." (3)

- 2 of these users + 2 others (who did not notice an issue until the landing page) ultimately were not willing to give up choice
- 1 who was initially concerned ultimately valued the tax benefit more

3

Questions about financials/ fees

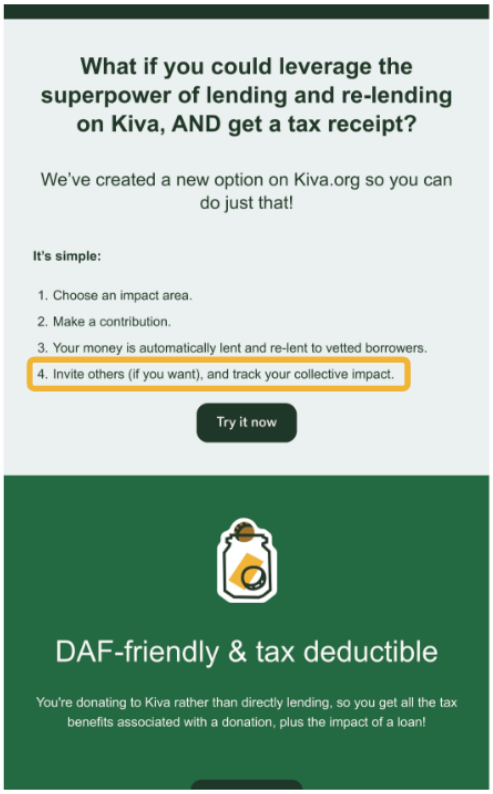
- "Is that in any way meaning less will end up going to the borrowers?" (2)
- "I would like it to be like auto-lending...The other programs that I've seen are loaned once and then as it comes back it goes right to Kiva." (1) → *Resolved on landing page*
- "I don't know what the language is within Kiva of the amount I'm lending vs the amount I donate directly to Kiva...That could be a point of friction." (1)

2

Other comments

- "Will I know which loans have been made...to keep that sense of connection?" (1) → *Resolved on landing page*
- "Withdrawal has helped me...I use Kiva as a rainy day fund." (1) → *No PMF*

No comments



Value of DAF support/ tax benefit

5 users were excited about a tax deduction

Mentioning a "tax benefit" is clear to people who value it. They care enough to have tried this before and understand it is not possible today.

However, **level of choice** became a blocker for many of these users.

- 2 remained excited and wanted to switch
- 3 (all of them were current autolenders) would not switch due to different category settings

3 users were unmotivated or confused by the tax benefit

2/3 didn't realize that their contributions weren't already tax-deductible

- Since they don't care, they haven't tried (and failed) to get a receipt in the past
- Talking about the tax benefit could **confuse and concern** non-target users

Mentioning a DAF had no negative reactions

- 3 users mentioned wanting to contribute from a DAF to fund loans
- 3 users mentioned that most of their giving comes from a DAF, and wanted to use the new product (but did not specifically say that they would use the DAF to contribute)
- 1 user had a DAF but *did not* want to use the new product - their priority was choosing loans

Users who did not talk about having a DAF did not raise any questions or concerns about what it meant

Recommendation: Expand outreach to a wider audience with DAF-focused messaging

Don't limit focus to current donors or auto-lenders

- It's hard to predict who values tax benefits or DAF support based on previous behavior
- The users who value these most may not be highly engaged with Kiva because of the pain point we are now solving

Message around DAF support, not taxes

- All users who wanted to use product had a DAF
- Less likely to confuse users who are not a fit (who we cannot accurately identify)
- DAF unblocks a new type of charitable wallet (whereas tax benefit merely reduces friction)

2

Right-sized choice

Some users just want to pick

These were primarily users recruited based on their annual survey results: they reported giving $10k+ to charity, are in the US, and said they did not look forward to choosing loans

Despite their responses in the annual survey, in interviews 3/4 said that they would be unwilling to give up choice

Current autolenders expected granular settings to match the filters available for loan choice

They were excited by the initial mention of a tax benefit (these were all people with a large balance)

- 2/3 would not switch without the ability to combine complex loan filters to define their own category
- 1 just wanted to specify a regional focus (Africa)

The 3 users who would use with the current level of choice wanted to use it in addition to choosing loans

- Curated funds for big $ and automation
- Loan choice to handpick a few loans each year

1

2

Recommendation: Streamline cross-product experience ASAP

Expect existing users to start a fund in addition to choosing some manual loans.

Position funds as *complementary to* choice

Users were interested in an additional way to give, not a full replacement

- Most impact automated with curated funds
- Preserve some minimal balance to handpick a few loans each year

Help users split their balance to achieve their preferred choice frequency

- Must-have: An easy way to use their current balance to start a fund

They will expect a seamless experience across both products

- Easy to find and use the product they want at a given moment in time
- A view into their overall impact with Kiva
- Transparent accounting
- Clarity when action is needed (idle/ lendable balance outside of funds)

1

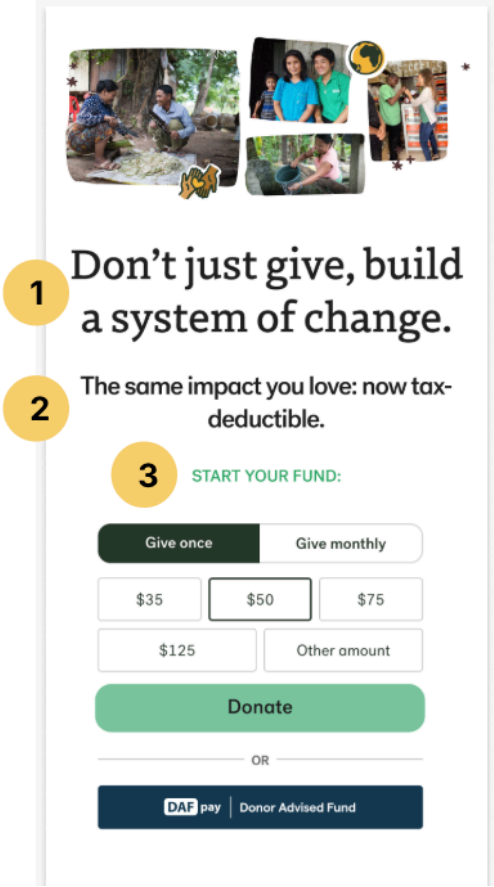
➡️ Explore this idea in Figma Make. Check

- Bonus: Guidance around how much money to preserve for loan choice (based on their preferred frequency)

➡️ Explore this idea in Figma Make. Try setting up a fund using your existing balance

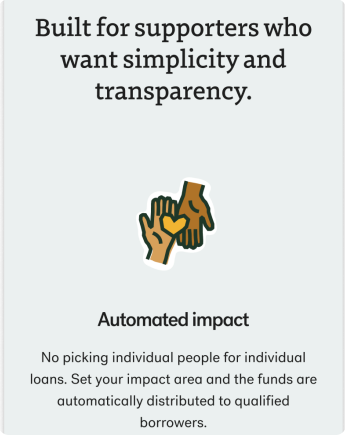
out the top and side nav

A few more notes on the landing page



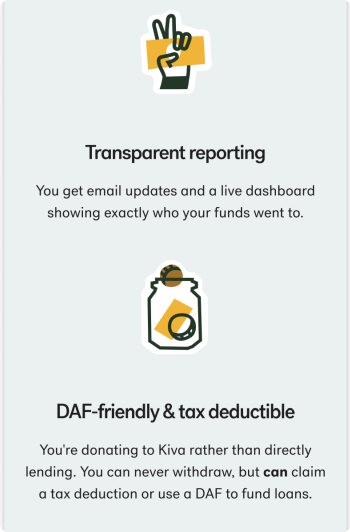
Above the fold

1. No comments on the headline
2. Some discussion around the "now tax-deductible" line, echoing what was said about the email
3. People didn't read "start your fund" here (making the use of "fund" surprising further down)



"No picking individual people for individual loans."

- This line stood out to many people.
- A few users *had been interested* based on the email (because they did not understand they were giving up choice) and realized for the first time that this product was not a fit



Clear

Some comments on mention of 'reporting' (see more below)

See notes on right-sized choice (above)

Comments on this section were primarily from

- auto-lenders, asking for more granular categories
- people who would switch, confirming that this works for them

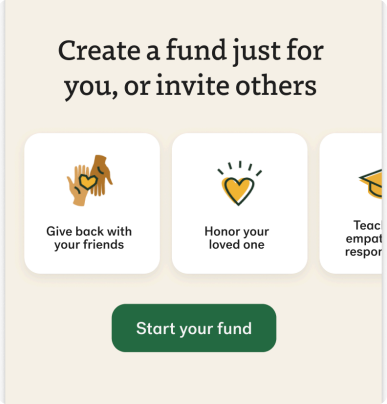
(People who wanted to handpick had already realized this product wasn't a fit)

Use of word 'fund' in header mid-page added friction for some users.

The first time they noticed this word was pretty far into the page and it felt jarring.

1

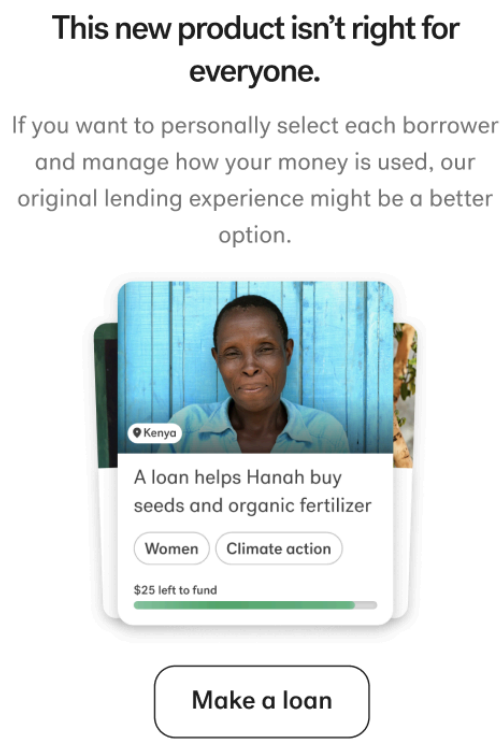
No one was *particularly* excited about the mention of 'sharing'...



But about half of participants eventually thought of a context where they might use this

- Birthday (2)
- Honor a loved one (1)
- Mention in a class they teach (1)

This supports an approach where we don't emphasize group features to hook this audience, but do show them ideas or CTAs later in their journey.



Clear

4

Curated funds vs loan choice

	Curated fund	Loan choice
Withdraw money	❌	✅
Tax-deductible	✅	❌
Pay with credit, debit	✅	✅
Pay with DAF	✅	❌
Automated impact	✅	❌
Choose each loan	❌	✅
Transparent reporting	✅	✅
Public impact page	✅	❌
Multiple contributors	✅	❌

Only a few people looked at this

- 1 commented that you *can* make a public impact page or automate impact today (eg. with loan choice) - wondered if that was changing

How do curated funds work?

1

You choose an impact area

Kiva supports people and communities that driving meaningful change around the world. You can support this broad mission, or narrow your focus.
EX: women, refugees, climate, and more.

2

You donate

To start your fund, simply make a donation at any amount (from $1 to $1M!)

Since you're donating to Kiva rather than directly lending, and we're a 501(c)(3), you get all the tax benefits associated with a donation, plus the impact of a loan! You can never withdraw, but **you can claim a tax deduction or use a DAF to fund loans.**

It was clear that money could not be withdrawn.

This was only an issue for 1 user, who treated their Kiva account like a rainy day fund.

Users wanted clarify sooner about the use of funds.

Specifically, they wanted to know how this model affects the amount of money getting to borrowers.

1. Will the money keep cycling? → *Not clear in the email*
2. What is the fee?⟶ *Currently at the bottom of a very long page*

4

3

Kiva lends

Your funds are automatically lent to vetted borrowers in your impact area. All backed by Kiva's 20 years of expertise and due diligence.

IS KIVA CHARGING INTEREST ON THESE LOANS? →

4

Borowers repay

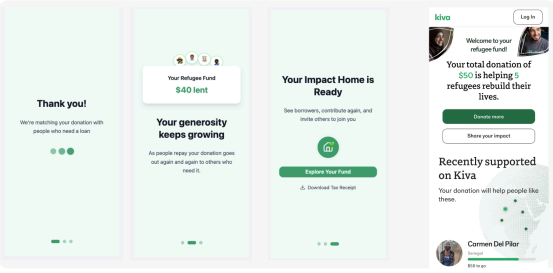
Kiva borrowers have a concrete plan to improve their lives, and 97% of borrowers repay their loans.

WHAT IF THEY CAN'T REPAY? →

5

Your money is re-lent, automatically

When loans are repaid, your money keeps cycling for more impact. **Kiva will use about 15% of the fund balance each year to support the teams and systems that make this lending network possible.**



Existing users didn't look at or comment on the impact page in detail.

They felt like they 'got it' at this point and assumed the impact page will be similar to what we provide today.

More insights in this project

View insights

Copied from Slack, written by Tess Which giving fund has the most number of contributors, 2nd highest funds raised ($), and and how did they find us? Mary Mary from ECG healthcare Management Consulting reached out to us from the Major Giving landing page "Our company has selected Kiva as the charity we would like to support for our holiday giving program. Can I setup a link to donate just for our company?" Channing offered her giving funds as an

Giving fund contributor recap - Dec 2025

Giving Fund Ad Test - Dec 2025

Optimizing Kiva's SMB Strategy - Jan 2025